## Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

## Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
    a. Explore where they buy food and groceries, if they have cooking appliances, and if they know how to cook food.

Actually, I love shopping from how do you say how going to market Rancho?
OK. Because you know, I feel like they have, like, some they have, like, natural food, you know, like kind of.
FQ: So do you take a car there? Do you drive to Rancho?
Yes, I do.
FQ: When you don't have a car, how do you get there?
I use the how you call it bus use the bus

FQ:  is a hard to get to Rancho on the bus?
Yeah, it is.
FQ:How long does it take you?
Umm Id say three to four hours
Three to four hours on a bus?
No, no, no, no. Actually, on the bus, take me like 20 minutes.
FQ: And then how long would it take for you to get there with the car

10 minutes, 10 minutes.

FQ: Do you have to take your kids with you when you go grocery shopping?
So all of that, always.

FQ: And then what kind of foods do you get?
Ohh. Plantains,  rice, beans, meat. fish. I love fish. potatoes and fruits. Yeah, they love fruits.
FQ: Do they usually eat the food that you make at home or they kind of picky?
Sometimes, sometimes they're they don't really like fish, so whenever I cook fish, they are like picking.

FQ: Uh, do they ever ask to get food from, like outside or anything like that?
Yeah, sometimes it will be like, can we eat McDonald's when I cant afford it.
Yeah, but when I cant. Sorry, I don't want money.
FQ: And then what do you have for cooking appliances?
I have. I have some pots and pans and things.
FQ: Are they good pots and pans you think?

Yeah.
FQ: Did they do the job?
Yeah, they do job.
FQ: Do you think they're like, do you think you would have to buy new ones soon?
Yeah.
FQ: Are they like rusting and stuff?
Some of them.
FQ: Do you think that affects the food sometime?
Yeah. So I I usually throw them away when I feel like, yeah, it's gonna take the food

FQ: do you have, like, utensils that you can like cook with as well?
Yeah, the egg thing and like, tongues.

FQ: and then you do know how to cook.
Yes, I do.
FQ: What do you know how to cook?

basically everything. I learned how to cook when I was like 10 years old. (Were you back in?) In Africa? Yeah.
FQ: And then who taught you how to cook?

my mom

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
    a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

    Yeah, I would say. I used to work. What I used to make wasn't, you know, like big enough. And my food stamp was reduced because I was working. And I also have that time I used to have a lot of bills and rent and all that. Even till now is still waiting. So I will be paying my rent, my bills. I don't know have enough money left and the EBT that we will receive would not, you know, Yeah, it was little.
FQ: And then how did that affect the kinds of foods you were able to get, like, how was the budgeting for everything?
I will say what we usually eat the most. They are like quite expensive cause sometime we like to shop from African market and they're really expensive. Umm, so yeah, like we took the $300.00 in African market. Its not enough.
FQ: do you ever have guests over at your house and you have to feed them, but you feel like you don't have enough for them like your sister, your mom or anything like that?
Yeah

FQ: And then I when you try to like buy things from the African market, what kind of things do you buy from there?

Yeah, food from home. So I'll dolay, And like, how do you say it fufu?

i. Explore the nature of the problem such as unemployment, low income, language barriers, and lack of knowledge about resources.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

Ohh, I'm sure I'll just make a work.

FQ: you sometimes feed your kids and not eat yourself. Like, do you just make sure that your kids are?

Ohh yeah, sure, sometimes a lot you need sometime. Yeah. Or sometime I'll have them eat 1st and the rest I'll eat.

FQ: How old is the little one?

And she's 23 months,

FQ: what about last year when she was a baby. And she only, like, drink formula. How was that?

She started eating she was one year old. So she started eating when she was one year old, but as a baby, she only drinks.

FQ: Were you like, breastfeeding her?

No, no, it was it hard to find formula and stuff like that.

Yeah.

FQ: Yeah, but she's completely healthy. Correct?

Yeah, perfectly.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.

So CCS just help us to get here to the USA and they also help us paying rent for like six months. So and later on the pass us to DWS. Refugee center. OK, so I'm still on the case right now and we start getting food stamp.

FQ: And then do you you have no income at the moment, how do you pay for rent and stuff?

I have housing

FQ: Were you ever like giving budget management classes just to know that like this is the income that you get and this is how you can budget it?

No

FQ: Did they ever teach you how to prepare foods or show you where to get foods and stuff like that? Like show you where like an African market is, or what the best grocery stores are or did you have to Figure that out that through the community.

Yeah, they did

FQ: Was it Helpful?

Umm, it was helpful. Yeah.
FQ: May I ask when did you come to the US?
In 2018,
FQ: And then so when they showed you everything, they showed you where everything was, you were able to go?

I use buses to get there.
FQ: was that a struggle at the time?

Oh yeah it was hard

FQ: Was it hard to find time while being like employed to go get groceries, especially with having three kids now?

Yeah.

FQ: And then when you were employed, did you have a day specific to going and getting groceries like taking the bus and stuff like that?

Yeah. Saturdays because my sister, she doesn't work on Saturday, so I'll be using her car.

Sometimes she will go for overtime. So, you know, like just use the bus.

FQ: And then you're three kids. When you did work, Who took care of them? Or where were they?

they went to daycare.

FQ: Did you have to pay for that?

No.

ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

I would say help us get here. I would say also help us with all paperwork, which is green card, Social Security and  we used to get cash assistance before.
FQ: And yeah, that doesn't happen anymore?
No.
FQ: Are you still receiving support DWS support?
yeah
FQ: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of DWS?
yeah
FQ: OK, so do they help you with food or anything? Can you tell me more about that?
They give us food stamp, so which is. And what I'm using right now, like you know for food,

FQ: Do you think the amount that you get in food stamps is enough for you and your family?
Right now.

Yeah.

FQ: But when you're employed?
No.

FQ: And did they apply for you or did they show you how to apply?
They help me apply for.
FQ: So they taught you how to apply?

Yes

FQ:  and then do you have a computer at home for you to be able to apply to food stamps?

No, I have to go there.

FQ: is it hard to get there?

You know, it's like 25 minutes away. 25 minutes away by car.

iii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?
iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

Actually, What I wish to have taught me, to be honest. Like when I came first came here when I was 18 years old, like to send me back to school.
FQ: You think that could have helped you so much more, right?
Yeah.
FQ:  Can you tell me how you think that could have helped?
Umm, because like sometimes it's hard to get a job when you don't have a high school diploma from here. And also there's a lot of things that I'm, you know Im interesting into it that I can't do right now because I don't have any diploma from USA.
FQ: Do you wish they would have helped you with your education?
Yeah
FQ: And you think that would also have helped you with your income?
Yes.
FQ: But it's also like if your income was higher, you would receive less food stamps?
I think that would be better.

FQ:  you think it would be better to have a higher income and less food stamps?

Yeah.

d. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to determine when food became a problem: Can you tell me when food became a problem?
e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:
    i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?
    ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.
iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

Repeat i-iv for other programs they have used.

f. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have NOT used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months:
   i. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?
   ii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Have you asked your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you because they help refugees find food resources?
   iii. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>: Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

FSo you indicated the use of SNAP program, Can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?
Through CCS
FQ: And how did you apply for it?
They applied for us and then later on I used to work So they cut it off. OK so I have to go back to DWS so we apply for it. They (CCS )helped me apply
FQ: Is the website in English?
yes
FQ: Is that hard?
Umm, not really. I can read Like perfectly fine. It's just like speaking sometimes.
FQ: And then can you explain your experience with this program? how often do you use food stamps and how do you feel about it?
In a month, let's say so I usually receive it on the 11 of each month. So whenever you receive it like sometime. Ohh, you know like whenever I have access to my sister car we will go shopping. So maybe twice in a month.
FQ: And you think of the amount of money that you have is enough for the food that you need for twice in a month?
Yeah, right now.
FQ: And then how do you feel about it? Does it make you feel comfortable?
Yes.
FQ: How does it make you feel like comfortable?
Helps me with food, So which is great.
FQ: Can you explain the benefits that you get out of it?
food. The main thing food.
FQ: Can you tell me about the foods you received from them?
So actually it's like money in the card. So you just pick any food you like, but not like cook food.

FQ: What kind of vegetables do you get?
Any

FQ: Do you ever get protein like meat?
Yes I do.
FQ: Do you feel like you get enough for the month or is that more of a special occasion?
It's OK for now.
FQ: Do you get beans and rice?
Beans and beans. I usually get it for my wic card.
FQ: And then what percentage of food do you think you get from food stamps? Like how much of the food that you have are home right now is from stamps.
Umm, actually right now we are out of the food. Let's be honest. Yeah, I have, but I still have some meat. So I'm about to cook it right now,
FQ: But you would say, like the 11th of the month, when you go and buy all the food. How much food do you get from the food stamps?
My oldest, She's five years old. She's not on the wic anymore. It's just those two, so I will say $52 for vegetable a month and on food stamp right now I receive 800 something. So I will usually use it on the 1st of each month I use my wic card to buy some vegetable and fruit and also milk. On the 11 I use 3 to 4 hundred to buy some food stuff. Yeah, hey, around like the 20 of each month I use the rest of the food stamp

FQ: And you kind of struggle to keep that food for the rest of the month?
Yeah.
FQ: And then I'm gonna ask about the wic program? Can you tell me how you heard about it and how you applied?

from the hospital.

FQ: Is it when you gave birth?

Yes
FQ: So even though you had a little one you didn't know about it?
No, my first one I did know about it, but everything is they used to, you know, like give the paper. So it was hard for me to pick the food, so I just leave it.I didn't use that. Just quit. when I gave birth to my last one, I heard that it was easy.They just put everything in the cart. You just swipe it.
FQ: Is it still specific foods then you receive a certain amount of money for each specific thing?

yeah
FQ: And then can you tell me your experience with this program? Like what was your experience with wic?

Honestly good, Great. has helped me a lot.
FQ: Can you tell me just about the foods that they approve and how you feel about that?
Ohh actually.I usually receive $52 a month.
FQ: Is that for all of the food?

No, just for fruits and vegetables And I also received a whole milk whole milk two gallon. And since 6 cans, no eight can of beans and cereals.
FQ: was it hard to get used to the things that WIC approved and not?

Yeah

FQ: how long did it take for you to get used to it?
Honestly two months.

FQ: Were you still picking out things and then not being approved by the WIC program?
Yes, (the card would decline). It was non Wic.
FQ: Then can you tell me about the foods that you receive from with, like what kind of you said fruits and vegetables?
Milk, beans Yeah, cereal, cheese. Sometimes hard to get it cheese..
You know, like sometimes though have cheeses for wic, sometimes they won't.
so every month it's different? it depends on the market though.
FQ: And then are there specific markets you have to go to that take wic?
Yeah, yeah.
FQ: What kind of market do you have to go?
Walmart, Smiths, Rancho Market.
FQ: Would you say you specifically go to Rancho the most? Is it the most accessible to you?
Yes, yes.
FQ: And then what percent of your food do you think you get from the WIC program?How long does that food last you per month?
I would say just like few days.

FQ: So and then how long does the food that you get from food stamps last?

I would say 3 weeks

FQ: Do you have to stretch out the food and make it last?
Yes. OK.
FQ: Do you feel like you're getting enough nutrients out of the food and getting enough? Do you feel like you eat until you're full or you eat until you know that you can stop?
Until Im full.
FQ: And then you said that you did get food from the church.Can you tell me how you heard about that?
Ohh, I'm Mormon. That time we really struggling. So my mom went to Africa and she left me with my brothers. so it was hard for us, you know? So we have to get some assistance from the church. (You got food from the temple right?) Yeah.

FQ: And then was it like grocery bags for you specifically? Like people would come up and give it to you? Or would you have to go to food pantry?

so you have to go to the shop like. Went to the home shop. And like so, you will talk to the Bishop first. And you ask you what you like, what you don't like, so you will write it out, and then, you know, you go to the store and pick those items.

FQ: So what kind of store do you go to?

their own store in the temple, they have their own stores. You just have to bring the bishop paper. So they'll approve the paper you give it to the front desk, and then they will help you pick the things up.

FQ: And then can you tell me your experience with that? Was that a hard experience?

they're so helpful. So they usually will help you with those stuff easily.

FQ: And then what kind of food did you receive from them? What kind of selection did they have?

Actually I would say almost everything.

Yeah, I'll say everything

FQ: would you would get up big amount or little ?

big amount because my brother used to live with me when my mom travels.

FQ: Do you still get food from church?

No, no, only get it, like twice.

FQ: OK, what can I ask why you stopped, or if they had stopped?

Actually, we did get it in the 1st place because my mom left me with my brothers. So my EPT was not enough for all of us, so we have to go to the bishop and talk to him. So we did get help twice. And yeah, when my mom came back, I just dropped them back.

FQ: And you had enough for yourself?

Yeah.

FQ: And then what would you say like at that time? How much food would you get from the church compared to the food that you would get from food stamps? Do you think you would have a lot of food stamps leftover or you would also use up?

Also using food stamps. Yeah.

FQ: And then you can you explain what kind of foods you would have if you did get food from the church and wic and food stamps? I understand that there was one more person at this household who also needed to eat.

So yes, it was five people and you couldn't. No, it was more.

FQ: How many do you have?

I have six six siblings and they were all here, so it was ten people.

FQ: Does your mom go back to Africa and leave the kids with you a lot or no?

No, just that one time that she was sick.So she needed some traditional, you know, medicine.

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

So how important to you is eating food from back home or your culture?
Very important,

FQ; even for your kids.?
Yes, yes.
FQ: You want them to grow up eating foods from your culture?
yeah
FQ: Do they like it?
Yeah, they love it.
FQ: what kind of foods from your culture do you guys eat?
Ohh, we have a lot. so we have dole. We have ahoy. We have achoy. so there's a lot of food.
FQ: Is it hard to make because it requires a lot of ingredients and stuff like that?
Yes, a lot. And also you know like here is America. So it's hard to find those.
So like the market, the price is really hard like high compared to the one back home.
FQ: can I ask if you how to cultural food as like a special occasion food or more of like an everyday food?
Umm, occasion food Yeah.
FQ: Whats more like your everyday food from your culture?
Umm, I would say ocra.
FQ: do ever have meat in your food?
Yeah, meat and dried fish?

FQ: Do you have that everyday?
No, actually I like to vary
FQ: if you wanted to, have it every day, could you?
No, it's so expensive. You can't.
FQ: what kind of vegetables are like I'm back home or cultural foods? Where do you get them from? You get them from the African market. You said.
Yes. Sometime. You can get it from the Chinese store.
FQ: Can you only find it at the African market and Chinese?
Yes.
FQ: What kind of vegetables are like so specific to like African cultures?

Id say dole.  And I don't know how to say it in English, actually dole is not an English word. Eege, And Ocra, we can get it from the Chinese store and also American store..
FQ: are those expensive for you to get?
yeah. So for you to cook like a meal from an African store. You have to spend up to 200 just one meal.

FQ: And how long would that meal last?
just two days
FQ: What about the food that you make?
Reheat and eat. Also cause you know I am used to cooking big portion. Of course I have a lot of siblings, so it happens a lot.

FQ: did CCS or DWS help you with finding foods from your culture?

No. They only showed me Walmart, smiths, so you have to figure it out yourself.

FQ: were there, a people, like a community of people to help you

people from our home country that used to live here before us. So you know, hey, this African market, you know, they will give us the address and we would just Google it like African store.

FQ: Were they able to help you get there?

sometimes yeah,

FQ: you still receive that help?

no, only when you are newSo they will take you shopping.

FQ: do you use the farmers market to buy foods from your culture?

No

**Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)**

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

FQ: You think everybody who has food assistance programs available to them uses them?

Yeah.

FQ: Have you ever met someone who you thought needed them but did not use them?

no

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

FQ: do you like a food pantry or a church near you? Or like food delivery service or anything like that. That just was free. Would that help you?

Oh, yeah,

FQ: Can you tell me how food delivery would help you?

Because, you know, I have  to struggle, you know, to, you know, take the bus or something. Yeah.

FQ: Do you think it's mentally exhausting or physically exhausting to go to the grocery store?

Yeah, just physically

FQ: Do you leave a full day just for groceries?

sometimes

FQ: You struggle to make meals after going to the grocery stores?

Yeah, sometimes just, you know, take my bag. Lay down the next day, I'll cook.

FQ: what do they eat when you don’t cook

fruit or egg

FQ: So you wish you had access to something that would deliver like the foods that you wanted and stuff like that to your home so you wouldn't have to struggle to go get it?

Actually that's kind of Laziness, so I will say no.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

Maybe help like helping them get better job. because like whenever you go to them to find you a job, they usually find you, you know like? low pay job, things like that.

FQ: Do you believe that income is 100% correlated with the amount of food that's in the household?

To me. I'll say yes.

FQ: Like when you did have an income with the amount of food that you had in the household more or less?

In my case, I would say no because you know, I had a lot to pay, you know, like when I use not, I barely got my housing. So I'll have my rent, electricity like things like down.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

FQ: Like tell me more about your mom helping you. I'm like, how does she like help you buy food?

Ohh yeah, sometime whenever I don't have food she will. I would just call her. She will give me her credit card to use.

FQ: How much you end up like buying?

Whenever she gave me, she gives 100 or 150.

FQ: What kind of things do you end up buying?

Umm sometime I will buy. How do you call it? My favorite store. Rancho market. I will then grab some food, stuff like sweet potatoes, so meat, fish, just depends.

FQ: do you have to be really, really struggling for you to call your mom?

No, I just call, and be like hey mom, we don't have food, something like that, you know? She’ll just be like, come get my card or sometimes she will pick me up and get us some food.